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Verified Early Warning, Lawful Reporting and Community Safety: Church Engagement and Perceived Insecurity Reduction in Abuja, Nigeria

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Abstract

Background: Community-security engagement and early-warning support is frequently invoked in Christian responses to insecurity, but its relationship with community-level outcomes requires specific measurement. **Objective:** To determine the relationship between community-security engagement and early-warning support and perceived reduction of community insecurity (PRCI) in the FCT, Abuja. **Methods:** The study used the 586-response CECIQ household survey drawn from 24 clusters across all six FCT Area Councils. Scale reliability, item distributions, weighted Spearman association and the prespecified survey-weighted simultaneous model were examined; the full model used 366 complete cases and Holm correction across five hypotheses. **Results:** CSEW had weighted $M=3.652$ ($SD=0.868$), $\alpha=0.800$, $\omega=0.803$. Its weighted association with PRCI was $\rho=0.445$ (pairwise $n=503$). In the full model, $B=0.269$, 95% CI [.161, .376], standardized $\beta=0.284$, Holm $p<.001$, with $\Delta R^2=0.059$. The relationship remained positive in the equal-weight sensitivity analysis. **Conclusion:** Verified early warning, lawful reporting, clear risk communication and safeguarding formed the strongest distinct Church-engagement domain associated with PRCI in the FCT dataset. The finding supports a practical model in which churches strengthen community preparedness and truthful information flow while remaining outside investigation and coercive enforcement. For church-based early warning to be credible, trust must be disciplined by verification, lawful referral, confidentiality and professional safeguarding.

Keywords: early warning; community security; church engagement; risk communication; lawful reporting; safeguarding; human security; Abuja

1. Introduction

Early warning is often discussed as a technical function of governments or security institutions, yet the first signs of community tension are frequently encountered in households, worship spaces, markets and local networks. Religious communities can therefore contribute information, interpretation and referral before incidents escalate. That potential is ethically double-edged: trusted channels can reduce panic when they verify information, but the same trust can amplify rumours, stigmatization or vigilantism when verification and lawful referral are absent.

The FCT is a suitable setting for examining this boundary. Recent security reporting recorded incidents across all six Area Councils rather than only in the metropolitan core (EUAA, 2026), while Nigeria's national strategy places lawful protection within a wider field of prevention, coordination and community cooperation. ECOWAS similarly links early warning to mediation and coordinated response. The theological question is therefore not whether churches should act as security agencies; it is whether they can help communities recognize risk, communicate truthfully, protect vulnerable persons and connect concerns to authorized responders (Economic Community of West African States [ECOWAS], 2008; Federal Republic of Nigeria, Office of the National Security Adviser, 2019).

The CECIQ operationalized community-security engagement and early-warning support (CSEW) through five observable practices: safety/preparedness forums, verification of warnings, lawful reporting channels, clear and non-inflammatory risk communication, and safeguarding/referral procedures. This article isolates that



prespecified objective because CSEW emerged as the strongest distinct Church-engagement dimension in the full model.

1.1 Aim and hypothesis

The article addresses the prespecified question: what relationship exists between community-security engagement and early-warning support and PRCI among adult residents of the FCT? The null hypothesis stated that CSEW had no adjusted relationship with PRCI after simultaneous entry of the five Church-engagement constructs and prespecified covariates.

2. Materials and Methods

The parent doctoral study used a stratified multistage household survey across all six Area Councils of the Federal Capital Territory (Abaji, AMAC, Bwari, Gwagwalada, Kuje and Kwali). Area Council was the explicit stratum and four communities or enumeration-area equivalents were selected within each council, giving 24 field clusters. Within clusters, households were selected systematically from fresh or verified listings, and one eligible adult was selected within each participating household using a Kish-style random procedure. Eligibility required age 18 years or older and at least 12 months of residence. The sample was not restricted to Christians because the public consequences of Church action were intended to be judged by residents across faith positions and levels of Church contact.

The Church Engagement and Community Insecurity Questionnaire (CECIQ) measured five Church-engagement domains with five items each: theological peace education and moral formation (TPEMF), mediation/dialogue/public advocacy (MDPA), socioeconomic empowerment/humanitarian relief/psychosocial care (SEHPC), community-security engagement/early-warning support (CSEW), and institutional/interfaith collaboration (IIC). Perceived reduction of community insecurity (PRCI) was measured with seven items covering everyday safety, fear and tension, cohesion, access to help, incident response, protection of vulnerable persons and recovery/resilience. Items used a 1–5 agreement scale with separate 0 = not observed/not applicable and 9 = prefer not to answer codes; 0 and 9 were excluded from scale means. Three optional open-ended questions captured helpful actions, weak or unsafe practices and priority improvements.

Instrument development included expert review by a seven-member multidisciplinary panel, cognitive pretesting with 12 adults, and a separate 60-person pilot in communities excluded from the main study. The pilot showed McDonald's omega values of .79–.89 and Cronbach's alpha values of .78–.88 across the six scales and prompted targeted wording/translation revisions, including clearer distinction between lawful early-warning reporting and rumour circulation. In the main data, alpha ranged from .796 to .875 and omega from .798 to .879.

The field target was 642 household contacts. The analytical file contained 586 questionnaires (578 complete and eight partial), an operational response rate of 92.4% after exclusion of eight ineligible contacts. Scale-specific valid samples ranged from 524 to 569; the survey-weighted simultaneous model used 366 respondents with all required scales and covariates across the 24 clusters. Weighted Spearman correlations described bivariate relationships. The primary inferential model regressed PRCI on all five Church-engagement scores simultaneously and adjusted for Area Council, years of residence, age, sex, Church contact and insecurity exposure. Supplied final weights and cluster-robust standard errors were used, and the family of five prespecified hypotheses was controlled with Holm's sequential adjustment. An equal-weight model was retained as a sensitivity analysis.

The study was designed to avoid collection of operational intelligence or identifiable victim information. Fieldwork proceeded only after written institutional clearance and required permissions. Consent was documented before participation; research assistants were trained in neutral administration, distress recognition, confidentiality, referral and safe handling of security-sensitive material. Exact household locations were not retained in the analytical dataset.



3. Results

CSEW produced a weighted mean of 3.652 (SD=0.868) and satisfactory internal consistency (Cronbach's $\alpha=0.800$; McDonald's $\omega=0.803$). The scale's item pattern shows where the practice was visible and where public reach remained uneven.

Table 1. CSEW item-level response pattern

Item	Short operational indicator	Agree %	Not observed %	Mean
CSEW1	Community safety/preparedness forums	52.4	6.5	3.459
CSEW2	Warnings verified before circulation	68.1	6.8	3.767
CSEW3	Lawful reporting channels	56.7	9.6	3.534
CSEW4	Timely, clear, non-inflammatory messages	59.5	9.0	3.500
CSEW5	Safeguarding/referral procedures	68.2	3.6	3.755

Note. Agree % uses valid 1–5 responses for agreement/strong agreement; not-observed % uses all 586 response records.

Figure 1. Item-level profile of community-security engagement and early-warning support.

3.1 Relationship with PRCI

The weighted Spearman relationship between CSEW and PRCI was positive ($\rho=0.445$; $n=503$). In the primary survey-weighted simultaneous model, CSEW retained an adjusted coefficient of $B=0.269$, 95% CI [.161, .376], standardized $\beta=0.284$; Holm $p<.001$. Its incremental contribution was $\Delta R^2=0.059$. The result was interpreted as an adjusted association, not as proof that the practice caused a reduction in recorded crime.

Table 2. Statistical summary for CSEW

Metric	Result
Weighted construct mean	3.652
Weighted SD	0.868
Cronbach α	0.800
McDonald ω	0.803
Weighted ρ with PRCI	0.445 ($n=503$)
Adjusted B	0.269
95% CI	[.161, .376]
Standardized β	0.284
Holm-adjusted p	<.001
ΔR^2	0.059

Figure 2. Researcher interpretation of the CSEW pathway to human-security outcomes.

The coded H1–H3 fields placed verified warning and lawful reporting in 178 respondent references (30.4%). Professional training/referral improvement was the most frequent category overall (270; 46.1%), reinforcing the need for competence and formal referral pathways rather than improvised security action.



4. Discussion

CSEW was not simply the strongest bivariate correlate of PRCI after IIC; it was the strongest unique predictor in the weighted simultaneous model. This matters because the coefficient was estimated after adjustment for four other Church-engagement domains and six contextual covariates. The result indicates that practical safety communication and referral contributed information beyond general religious formation, welfare, mediation and institutional cooperation.

The item pattern clarifies the mechanism. Verification of warnings and safeguarding/referral had the highest agreement levels, while lawful reporting channels and clear risk communication were less consistently visible. The study's strongest statistical domain therefore still contains an implementation gap: community trust is useful only when there is a reliable route from concern to authorized action. ECOWAS prevention practice and Nigerian community-policing scholarship support this distinction between community information and state coercive authority (ECOWAS, 2008; Ordu & Nnam, 2017).

From a Christian ethical perspective, early warning is best understood as truthful neighbour-protection. It requires resisting sensationalism, protecting the identity of threatened persons, checking information before circulation and refusing collective blame. This framing is especially important in a religiously plural city where a mistaken or partisan warning can itself become a security event. The Church's contribution is therefore bounded by verification, confidentiality, non-discrimination and referral.

The open-ended categories reinforced that emphasis. Verified warning and lawful reporting appeared in 178 respondent references (30.4%), while professional training/referral improvement was the most frequent category overall. The data thus point beyond informal goodwill toward trained practice, defined contacts and reviewable procedures.

4.1 Practical implications

- Establish named, periodically tested referral contacts with authorized agencies and qualified safeguarding/professional services.
- Train clergy, youth leaders and communication teams to distinguish verified warning from rumour, political messaging and public accusation.
- Use written protocols for confidentiality, consent, safeguarding, escalation and after-action review.
- Integrate safety forums with interfaith/community actors so that warning channels do not become denominational or identity silos.
- Measure reach and follow-through, including whether warnings were acknowledged, referred and resolved without exposing vulnerable persons.

4.2 Limitations

CSEW and PRCI were measured at one time point from the same respondents, so temporal sequence and causal direction cannot be established. The outcome represents perceived community improvement rather than verified incident reduction. Not-observed responses show uneven public reach, and the full-model analysis used complete cases. The article therefore supports an association between observed Church safety practice and perceived human-security improvement, not a claim that churches prevent a quantified number of crimes.

5. Conclusion

Verified early warning, lawful reporting, clear risk communication and safeguarding formed the strongest distinct Church-engagement domain associated with PRCI in the FCT dataset. The finding supports a practical model in which churches strengthen community preparedness and truthful information flow while remaining outside investigation and coercive enforcement. For church-based early warning to be credible, trust must be disciplined by verification, lawful referral, confidentiality and professional safeguarding.



Declarations

Declaration	Statement
Ethics and consent	Fieldwork proceeded only after written institutional clearance and required permissions. Adult participation was voluntary; informed consent was documented; the questionnaire was anonymous and did not retain exact household locations.
Funding	No external grant funding is declared for this study.
Competing interests	The authors declare no competing interests relevant to the study.
Data availability	The de-identified analytical dataset, codebook and quality-assurance records are held by the research team. Access may be considered for legitimate scholarly verification subject to ethics, confidentiality and data-protection requirements.
Author contributions	S.D.O.: conceptualization, investigation, data curation, formal analysis and original drafting. C.O.N.: supervision, methodology review, interpretation and critical revision. A.K.: co-supervision, theological interpretation and critical revision. All authors approved the submitted version and accept responsibility for the work.
AI-assisted editorial disclosure	AI-assisted tools were used only for editorial organization, language refinement and document production. They were not treated as authors or evidence. Numerical findings were retained from the verified study dataset and analysis records; human authors and editors remain responsible for claims, citations and interpretation.
Related publications / dataset transparency	This article (e006) is part of a coordinated publication series derived from the same doctoral FCT CECIQ study. It reports the distinct focus of the prespecified CSEW objective concerning verified warning, lawful reporting, preparedness and safeguarding. Companion articles use the same participant dataset for different prespecified or clearly delimited questions. Shared methods and sample descriptions are disclosed to prevent the appearance of independent replication.
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